

French Onion Meatballs with Creamy Mashed Potatoes and Green Beans

Status: Stage 1 Draft

Weekly folder: `weekly-plans/2026/week-28/`

Category: Beef

Source or inspiration: Next-week family menu idea

Date added: 2026-07-04

Planning Summary

- Servings: 4
- Estimated prep time: 25 minutes
- Estimated cook time: 45 minutes
- Protein: Ground beef
- Cuisine or flavor direction: French onion-style beef gravy, savory, cozy, rich
- Best day to cook: Tuesday
- Perishability notes: Uses ground beef and fresh green beans. Cook by midweek.

Equipment

- Large deep skillet
- Large pot
- Potato masher
- Sheet pan or plate for shaped meatballs
- Small bowl

Ingredients

Assume nothing is on hand. Include quantities for everything used.

Quantity	Ingredient	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Notes
1 1/2 lb	Ground beef	85/15 or 90/10	Ground turkey	Meatballs
1 large	Egg	Large	2 tbsp milk plus 1 tbsp extra panko	Meatball binder
1/2 cup	Panko breadcrumbs	Plain	Regular breadcrumbs	Meatballs
1/4 cup	Milk	Whole or 2 percent	Half-and-half	Meatballs
1 tbsp	Worcestershire sauce	Classic	Soy sauce	Meatballs
1 tsp	Garlic powder	Ground	2 cloves fresh minced garlic	Meatballs
1 tsp	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt, use less	Meatballs
1/2 tsp	Black pepper	Freshly ground	Ground black pepper	Meatballs
1 tbsp	Olive oil	Extra-virgin or regular	Neutral oil	Browning
3 large	Yellow onions	Thinly sliced	Sweet onions	Gravy

Quantity	Ingredient	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Notes
3 tbsp	Butter	Unsalted	Salted, reduce added salt	Gravy
1 tsp	Dried thyme	Dried	1 tbsp fresh thyme	Gravy
3 cups	Beef broth	Low-sodium	Beef stock	Gravy
1 tbsp	Worcestershire sauce	Classic	Soy sauce	Gravy
2 tbsp	Arrowroot powder	Arrowroot starch	Tapioca starch	Gravy thickener
2 tbsp	Cold water	Cold	Broth	Arrowroot slurry
4 oz	Gruyere or Swiss cheese	Shredded	Provolone	Optional topping
2 1/2 lb	Yukon gold potatoes	Peeled or scrubbed	Russet potatoes	Mashed potatoes
5 tbsp	Butter	Unsalted	Salted, reduce added salt	Mashed potatoes
3/4 cup	Milk	Whole or 2 percent	Half-and-half	Mashed potatoes
1/3 cup	Sour cream	Full-fat	Greek yogurt	Mashed potatoes
1 tsp	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt	Potatoes, adjust to taste
1 lb	Green beans	Fresh trimmed	Frozen whole green beans	Side
1 tbsp	Olive oil	Extra-virgin or regular	Butter	Side
1 clove	Garlic	Fresh minced	1/4 tsp garlic powder	Side
1 tbsp	Lemon juice	Fresh	Bottled lemon juice	Side
1/4 tsp	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt	Side

Basic Instructions

1. Mix beef, egg, panko, milk, Worcestershire, garlic powder, salt, and pepper. Shape into 16 to 20 meatballs.
2. Brown meatballs in olive oil in a deep skillet. They do not need to cook through yet. Transfer to a plate.
3. Add butter and onions to the skillet. Cook over medium heat 18 to 25 minutes, stirring often, until onions are deep golden and soft. Add thyme.
4. Add beef broth and Worcestershire. Return meatballs to the skillet, cover, and simmer 12 to 15 minutes, until meatballs reach 160 degrees F.
5. Stir arrowroot with cold water. Add to the simmering gravy and cook 1 to 2 minutes, until glossy and thickened. Add cheese over the meatballs if using, cover briefly, and let melt.
6. Meanwhile, boil potatoes in salted water until fork-tender, about 15 minutes. Drain and mash with butter, milk, sour cream, and salt.
7. Saute green beans in olive oil until crisp-tender, 6 to 8 minutes. Add garlic for the last minute, then finish with lemon juice and salt.
8. Serve meatballs and gravy over mashed potatoes with green beans on the side.

Notes

- What might need testing: Whether the onion gravy is rich enough without cheese.
- Possible substitutions: Swiss is more budget-friendly than Gruyere.
- Prep-ahead ideas: Shape meatballs earlier in the day and refrigerate.
- Family preference concerns: Onion texture may matter; cook onions very soft for a smoother gravy feel.

Review Link

Review file: